Who Is There, and When? Twelve Things to Notice About How Dad's Days Are Covered

Everyday things to notice and write down this week about who helps and when, with no judging and no diagnosing.

You know Dad has help. You may be less sure who comes when, and what each person does once they're there. This guide names twelve everyday things to notice about how his days are covered and, for each one, what to write down.

Notice and record. Don't interpret. This page looks at the arrangement around Dad, not at Dad: how he is doing is for his doctor, nurse or therapist to say. The kinds of help named below are ones the Family Caregiver Alliance, MedlinePlus, Medicare's discharge checklist and AARP's planning guide describe. The parts of the day, and the wording about what to write down, are ours.

Through the day

1 Morning

NOTICE Who is with Dad when the day starts, or who checks in, and how: in person, by phone, a knock on the door.

WRITE DOWN The name, the usual time, and what they do while they're there.

2 Daytime [1]

NOTICE Who comes and goes between breakfast and supper: family, friends, a neighbor, anyone who is paid to help.

WRITE DOWN Each visit this week, with the day and roughly how long it lasted.

3 Evening

NOTICE Who is around at supper and at bedtime, and who says goodnight by phone.

WRITE DOWN The name and what they do, on weekdays and on weekends.

4 Overnight

NOTICE Whether anyone stays over, and who would get the call if Dad phoned at night.

WRITE DOWN How it works today. If nobody in the family knows, write “not yet known.”

5 Weekends and days off

NOTICE How a Saturday differs from a Tuesday, and what happens when a regular helper is away.

WRITE DOWN What's different, and who fills in.

The work

6 Around the house [2]

NOTICE Who buys the groceries, cooks, cleans and does the laundry.

WRITE DOWN Each task with a name beside it, and how often it gets done.

7 Hands-on help [2]

NOTICE Whether someone helps Dad get dressed, take a shower or take his medicine, and who that is.

WRITE DOWN Who helps with what, as far as you've seen or been told. Describe the help, not how Dad is doing.

8 Appointments and rides [2] [3]

NOTICE Who arranges the medical appointments, who drives, who sits in, and who picks up prescriptions.

WRITE DOWN A name for each, and the next appointment anyone knows of.

9 Company [1] [2]

NOTICE Who visits just to visit, who phones, and which days.

WRITE DOWN The regular visitors and callers, and their usual days.

The people

10 The one everyone calls [2] [4]

NOTICE Whose phone rings when something comes up, and who talks with the doctors and nurses.

WRITE DOWN That person's name, and how the news reaches the rest of the family.

11 Tasks everyone assumes are covered

NOTICE The jobs that come with “I think your sister does that.”

WRITE DOWN The task, who is thought to do it, and whether you've confirmed it with them.

12 What the main caregiver says is getting hard

NOTICE What the person doing the most tells you when you ask which parts are becoming difficult. Ask them. Don't go by how they seem.

WRITE DOWN Their answer in their own words, and the date you asked.

> **When a note isn't enough**
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> These notes are about who is there and what they do. If something you see while you're keeping them concerns you about Dad's health, tell his doctor or nurse; don't hold it for the page. For an emergency, call emergency services.

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't say what any of this means, whether Dad has enough help, or what should change. A blank line is a question to ask someone, not a finding. The people who assess Dad work out what the picture means, and they start better with a true account of this week.

Ready for the next step?

You've noticed who is there for Dad and what each person does. The care interview asks about the rest: his living arrangement, his typical day and each area of daily life, in order, so nothing important is left out, and turns your answers into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

1. MedlinePlus (National Library of Medicine), Caregivers
2. Family Caregiver Alliance, Caregiving 101: On Being a Caregiver
3. Medicare (Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services), Your discharge planning checklist
4. AARP, Prepare to Care: A Planning Guide for Families

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